
Greek PM urges Burnham to return Elgin Marbles permanently

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In Pictures via Getty Images: Some of the Parthenon sculptures in the British Museum. The sculptures are damaged, with some missing limbs and heads

The Greek prime minister has called on Andy Burnham to find the “political will” to send the Parthenon sculptures back to Greece.

Kyriakos Mitsotakis wrote in the Guardian that returning the classical treasures, also known as the Elgin Marbles in the UK, would “send a powerful signal” but would require “courage”.

The sculptures have been on display in the British Museum since the 19th Century, though Greece has long disputed the legality of their removal.

Mitsotakis and his government have previously held talks with the British Museum about the sculptures, but the two have so far failed to reach an agreement, with Greek authorities seeking their permanent return.

The Greek PM used the recent fanfare generated by the loan of the Bayeux Tapestry to the British Museum to restate his country's claim to the Elgin Marbles.

“Nobody would seriously contemplate cutting what survives of the tapestry in two and displaying half in London and half in Bayeux, and claiming this was an adequate way to understand it,” he wrote on Thursday.

“Yet that is exactly what happened to the Parthenon sculptures.”

His comments come after British Museum director Nicholas Cullinan suggested that the recent arrangement struck between the UK and France, after decades of rejected requests to borrow the medieval embroidery, offered hope of a deal with Greece over the Elgin Marbles.

Mitsotakis said he was “surprised at the recent suggestion from the museum that the Bayeux Tapestry loan might provide a template for an agreement over the Parthenon sculptures”, adding: “I do not believe it does.”

“Greece cannot accept any arrangement that would require it to recognise the British Museum's ownership of the sculptures, or a scheme that would mean we ‘borrow’ parts of our own monument,” he wrote.

Instead, he urged Burnham to stand by his previous comments on the sculptures and find a way of returning them for good.

This would be a “decisive step”, Mitsotakis said, that would “reunite the sculptures and transform a historic dispute into a unique act of cultural friendship”.

Back in 2023, several years before he returned to government and became prime minister, Burnham said the sculptures should be returned to Greece with “no strings attached”.

For years, he supported a change in the law to allow for this. But last month, he told the Financial Times that “ultimately it's an issue for the British Museum”, adding that “legally that's where that issue rests”.



Bloomberg via Getty Images: Many of the Elgin Marbles originate from the Parthenon in Athens

British ambassador Lord Elgin was granted permission by the Ottoman Empire, the governing authority in Athens at the time, to remove some of the marble statues in the early 19th Century.

They were created between 447BC and 432BC to decorate the Temple of Athena - what is now known as the Parthenon, in the Acropolis in Athens.

After an 1816 parliamentary select committee deemed Elgin's actions legal, the sculptures entered the British Museum collection by an act of Parliament.

The Greeks dispute their removal was lawful and the demands to return the statues have been vocal.

The Parthenon gallery in the Acropolis Museum in the Greek capital was deliberately designed with spaces left for the sculptures in the British Museum.

Back in 2023, George Osborne, then the museum chair, told the BBC he was looking for a "more co-operative arrangement" after "quite a bitter disagreement" with the Greeks for more than 200 years.

Mitsotakis's latest comments appear to suggest a ramping up of rhetoric around the thorny issue once again.

Last month, Greece's health minister told Breitbart News he would like to see US President Donald Trump pressure the British to return the Parthenon pieces.

The British Museum's position - and that of the UK government - is that the law prevents the permanent return of items held in its collection, though loan agreements are common.

Campaigners point out that the British Museum Act could be amended. However, the UK government has not signalled that this is a priority.

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
urge	v.	敦促、力劝	urged Burnham to stand by his previous comments 敦促伯纳姆信守先前表态；名词 urge“冲动、强烈愿望”
dispute	v./n.	对.....提出异议；争端	Greece has long disputed the legality of their removal 希腊长期质疑移除的合法性；名词 a historic dispute 历史争端
reach an agreement	短语	达成协议	the two have so far failed to reach an agreement 双方迄今未能达成一致；对照 strike a deal
fanfare	n.	大张旗鼓的宣传、轰动	the recent fanfare generated by the loan of the Bayeux Tapestry 贝叶挂毯借展引发的轰动
loan	n.	出借、借展（藏品）	the loan of the Bayeux Tapestry 贝叶挂毯的借展；博物馆界用语，动词 lend 借出
contemplate	v.	设想、考虑	Nobody would seriously contemplate cutting... 没有人会当真考虑把.....一分为二；多用于否定句
arrangement	n.	安排、协议	the recent arrangement struck between the UK and France 英法之间最近达成的安排

词	词性	中文	备注
template	n.	范本、可循的先例	might provide a template for an agreement 或可成为达成协议的范本
scheme	n.	方案、安排（英式用语）	a scheme that would mean we “borrow” parts of our own monument 那种要我们“借”回自家文物的方案；另义“阴谋”
stand by	短语	坚持（立场、说过的话）	stand by his previous comments 信守他先前的表态；另义“支持”
for good	短语	永久地、一劳永逸	find a way of returning them for good 找到永久归还的办法；注意不是“为了好处”
no strings attached	短语	不附带任何条件	returned to Greece with “no strings attached” 无条件归还希腊
deem	v.	认定、视为	an 1816 parliamentary select committee deemed Elgin’s actions legal 1816 年议会特别委员会认定埃尔金的行为合法
vocal	adj.	大声疾呼的、直言不讳的	the demands to return the statues have been vocal 归还雕像的呼声一直强烈；本义“有声的”
hold	v.	收藏、保有	items held in its collection 其馆藏所保存的文物；另义“握住、举行”
rhetoric	n.	言论、话术、调门	a ramping up of rhetoric around the thorny issue 围绕这一棘手议题的言论升级
thorny	adj.	棘手的	the thorny issue 棘手的问题；本义“多刺的”

词	词性	中文	备注
amend	v.	修订（法律、条文）	the British Museum Act could be amended 《大英博物馆法》可以修订；名词 amendment 修正案
position	n.	立场、态度	The British Museum's position ... is that... 大英博物馆的立场是.....；另义“位置”
signal	v.	表明、暗示	has not signalled that this is a priority 并未表明此事属于优先事项；名词“信号”